



GREECE

Capital city: Athens**Area:** 50,942 sq miles
(131,940 sq km)**Population:** 11,000,000**Official language:** Greek**Major religions:** Christian
98%, Muslim 1%,
other 1%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Euro**Adult literacy rate:** 97%**Life expectancy:** 78 years**People per doctor:** 227**Televisions:** 477 per 1,000
people

GREECE

GREECE HAS A RICH HISTORY stretching back thousands of years. Yet the modern nation state only won its independence from the Turks in 1829, and it took control of some islands as recently as 1947. With its mountainous terrain, more than 2,000 scattered islands, and lack of natural resources, Greece was one of the poorest members of the European Union. However, its large shipping fleet and earnings from tourism have helped the economy: Greece adopted the Euro in 2002 and hosted the Olympic Games in Athens in 2004.

Main tourist nationalities

The majority of tourists visiting Greece are European, although large numbers of people also travel to Greece from North America and Australasia.



TOURISM

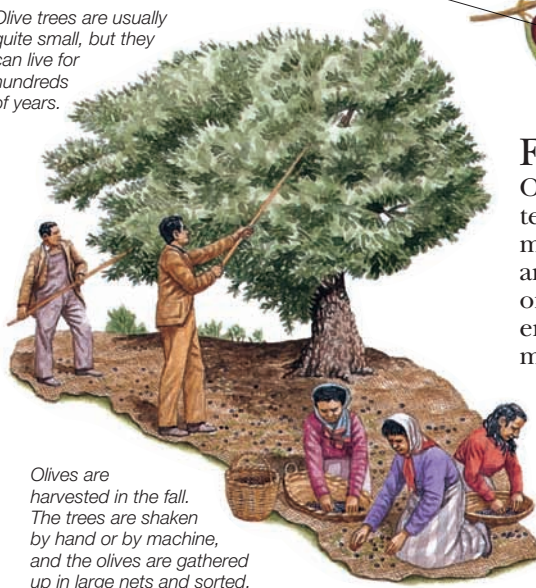
More than 14 million tourists a year come to Greece to enjoy the beautiful island scenery, the historic monuments, and the summer sun. Hotels, shops, and restaurants employ thousands of people to cater to the visitors, whose spending boosts the national economy enormously. The Greek government encourages tourism by giving grants for hotel building and the many Aegean islands are linked together by a comprehensive network of ferries. However, some islands are being developed too rapidly and suffer from problems such as water shortages.



Vacationers enjoying the beach on the island of Samos

Olives can be eaten when green or black, but must ripen to black when used for oil.

Olive trees are usually quite small, but they can live for hundreds of years.



Olives are harvested in the fall. The trees are shaken by hand or by machine, and the olives are gathered up in large nets and sorted.



SHIPPING

The cheapest and easiest way to travel around Greece is still by boat. Fleets of merchant ships connect the many islands with the mainland, moving supplies and industrial products, while ferries carry vehicles, local people, and tourists. Ship owners have built up huge fleets of ships, with the result that Greece now has the largest merchant fleet in the world.

Icons being blessed at an Easter ceremony



GREEK ORTHODOX CHURCH

The state religion of Greece is Greek Orthodox, making it the only officially Orthodox Christian country in the world. Almost every Greek is a member of the church. Priests play an important part in national events and are recognized as leaders of their local communities. The churches are not allowed statues, but many contain holy pictures of saints known as icons.

Olives are treated, pickled, and fermented before being eaten whole.



To make olive oil, the olives are ground to a thick paste before being pressed.

FARMING

Only a third of the mountainous terrain of Greece can be farmed, and much of the soil is poor. Many people are needed to work this land – nearly one-fifth of the Greek workforce is employed in agriculture, which is more than anywhere else in the European Union. The most important crop is olives, grown on hillsides across the country. Greece is the third biggest producer of olive oil after Italy and Spain, as well as a major producer of grapes and wine, citrus and other fruits, figs, cotton, tomatoes, and tobacco.



ATHENS

The ancient capital of Greece is dominated by the Acropolis and the dramatic ruins of the Parthenon temple. Much of the city, however, consists of modern buildings, for many people have left the countryside to seek employment in the city. As a result, Athens is one of Europe's most polluted cities; cars are banned from entering the city on certain days of the week in order to reduce the smog level.